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River a Friend ... and Foe

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POSTED: March 7, 2010

WHEELING - For many Ohio Valley communities, the Ohio River is a thing of beauty when the weather is fair and a source of destruction when it becomes too full.

But people continue to coexist with the river, not only to take advantage of its recreational offerings, but for commerce and industry. Some local cities have their own ports of call, such as Wheeling's Heritage Port, while others have built parks and marinas to accommodate residents and visitors.

Heritage Port is often a gathering place not only for Wheeling residents, but people across the Ohio Valley. Folks participate in and enjoy a variety of river-related activities, such as boating, kayaking and fishing. There are numerous free festivals, movie nights, car shows, concerts, cook offs, Fourth of July fireworks and more hosted at the port. And even when there is nothing scheduled at the site, people can be seen enjoying the view, watching the coal barges go by or eating lunch in the amphitheater on warm, sunny days. The adjacent Heritage Trail is popular, too.

Wheeling City Manager Robert Herron said the Ohio River not only provides recreational opportunities, but events held there help generate a positive economic impact on the city.

"In addition to adding to the quality of life of our residents, the river also supplies an unlimited source of water for our region," Herron noted.

While the river can be beautiful, it also can become a source of destruction when it floods. The latest major river and creek floods of 2004 and 2005 - caused by remnants of hurricanes - ravaged the region, causing millions of dollars worth of damage and wreaking havoc on many people's homes and lives.

But for some, putting up with flooding is worth what the river has to offer. Wheeling Island resident Norma Dorsch said she and her husband, Tom, enjoy their riverfront property - complete with a boat house and boat dock - on a daily basis from spring through New Year's Day.

"It's about 20 degrees cooler by the river. After a hot day, we get on the boat and sometimes go all the way to Moundsville to have dinner," Dorsch said. "We call it our little piece of heaven. ... It's a very peaceful time of our lives."

Their boat house is often a gathering place for neighbors, who also enjoy roasting hot dogs and marshmallows by the river. Dorsch especially likes how the river reflects lights at night from bridges and the downtown.

Longtime Islanders like the Dorsch's often make preparing for flooding into a party of sorts. For example, the last time the river rose to 46 feet, the Dorsch's moved their television into their motorhome, where they and neighbors watched a college football game.

"Flooding is a problem. ... We make the best of it," she said.

Rich Bibbo, village of Rayland administrator, has lived in Rayland, another river community, all of his life.

"It's called the beautiful Ohio. ... I think it's a beautiful river. It's a big river. This is a nice part of the U.S. People don't realize how nice it is. If you've grown up with the river, it's a way of life," Bibbo said.

Bibbo, who served as Rayland's mayor for 20 years, said he remembers as a child riding the ferry from neighboring Warrenton across the river to reach W.Va. 2. The ferry service, he estimated, ended during the early 1950s.

"It was a thrilling ride to go across the river," Bibbo said.

He noted Rayland has a marina. And a golf course also is situated next to the river.

Article Photos



Photo by Scott McCloskey
A coal barge floats down the foggy Ohio River near Wheeling Heritage Port. People use the river for recreation, commerce and industry.

"When you tee off, you can always hit it into the river - even if you don't want to. The river is a like a magnet (for golfballs)," Bibbo noted.

Powhatan Point Mayor Ryan Lee said his village's marina, situated at the mouth of Captina Creek that flows into the Ohio River, is being used more each day. He noted a Monroe County-based entrepreneur, Mike Willis, is planning to open a kayak and canoe rental business in Powhatan.

"He'll be offering instructional and safety lessons right here," Lee noted.

The Ohio River also is used on a daily basis to help keep the lights on. Barges can often can be seen pushing coal to power plants, where the substance is burned to generate electricity. For example, Consol Energy Inc. has its own barges to move coal. In 2008, the company pushed 23.6 million tons of coal, in addition to 8 million tons of its own coal, according to the Consol Web site.

"Consol Energy maintains a fleet of 29 vessels and more than 700 barges. The company's operations allow it to easily transport coal from mines with river load out facilities to customers along the Monongahela, Allegheny, and Ohio rivers. Additionally, Consol Energy can load coal from rail cars directly onto barges at its Alicia Transshipment Facility along the Monongahela River," the Web site states.

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